

New Homeowner Repair Emergency Budget: Stop Getting Blindsided by Costly Repairs — Action Checklist

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SET UP YOUR REPAIR FUND

- ☐ **Set Up Your Repair Fund:** Calculate 1-2% of your home's purchase price and commit to saving that amount each year for repairs, knowing that a \$400,000 home needs \$4,000-\$8,000 annually.
- ☐ **Set Up Your Repair Fund:** Start your repair fund immediately with whatever amount you can afford—even \$100 per month—because starting today matters more than waiting for a perfect number.
- ☐ **Set Up Your Repair Fund:** Add an extra 0.5% of home value to your first-year savings on top of the baseline, because deferred maintenance from the previous owner commonly surfaces within months of moving in.
- ☐ **Set Up Your Repair Fund:** Record the installation ages of your HVAC, water heater, roof, and sewer line to track their lifespans, because knowing replacement timing prevents you from being blindsided by \$5,000-\$25,000 bills.

ASSESS REPAIR URGENCY

- ☐ **Assess Repair Urgency:** Recognize true emergencies that require immediate professional help—gas smell, flooding, no heat in freezing temps, sewage backup, or burning electrical smells—because waiting even hours risks serious harm.
- ☐ **Assess Repair Urgency:** For gas smells, leave your house immediately and call the gas company emergency line from outside, because operating any electrical switches inside could trigger an explosion.
- ☐ **Assess Repair Urgency:** Call a plumber within one week for water heater failure signs like no hot water, leaking, or rust-colored water, because these units over 10 years old are near the end of their predictable lifespan.
- ☐ **Assess Repair Urgency:** Use a bucket and mark water level to track slow leak rates before calling a plumber, because this information helps professionals diagnose the problem faster and more accurately.

HANDLE REPAIRS WISELY

- ☐ **Handle Repairs Wisely:** Get 2-3 contractor quotes for any non-emergency repair to avoid overpaying, because prices vary significantly and you can make informed decisions with multiple estimates.
 - ☐ **Handle Repairs Wisely:** Compare replacement versus repair costs for appliances over 10 years old when estimates exceed \$500, because new units often make better financial sense than expensive repairs on aging equipment.
 - ☐ **Handle Repairs Wisely:** Call for emergency service immediately without comparison shopping when facing true emergencies, because the premium \$150-\$300 after-hours charge is worth avoiding life safety risks.
 - ☐ **Handle Repairs Wisely:** Address running toilets within one month even though they are not emergencies, because a single running toilet can waste 200-300 gallons of water per day until it is fixed.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.